The Metamorphosis of Justin Jones

By Bruce Coville

Justin Jones shot out the front door of the house where he lived-not *his* house, just the place where he was forced to live-and ran until he could no longer hear his uncle's shouts. Even then he didn't feel safe. Sometimes Uncle Rafe's anger was so powerful it propelled the man onto the street after Justin.

He leaned against a tree, panting and gasping for breath. The air burned in his lungs. He pressed his face against the tree, wishing he could melt into its rough bark and be safe.

INTRODUCTION

In The Metamorphosis of Justin Jones by Bruce Coville, a mistreated and unwanted boy makes a difficult choice between eternal untroubled youth and a future filled with untold pain and promise.

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When he finally opened his eyes again, Justin noticed an odd mist creeping around the base of the tree- Curious, he stepped forward to investigate. As he circled the tree he heard an odd whispering sound and felt a tingle in his skin. The mist covered the street ahead of him-a street he had never seen before.

At the end of the street he saw a strange, old-fashioned looking building. In the window were the words ELIVES MAGIC SUPPLIES. *I could sure use a little magic about now,* thought Justin. He tried the door. It opened smoothly. Magicians' paraphernalia was scattered everywhere. Top hats, capes, scarves, big decks of cards, and ornate boxes covered the floor, the walls, the counters. At the back of the shop stretched a long counter with a dragon carved in the front. On top of the counter stood an old-fashioned brass cash register. On top of the cash register sat a stuffed owl.

Justin wandered to one of the counters. On it stood an artillery shell, thick as his wrist. Attached

was a tag that said LISTEN.

Remembering the big seashell his mother used to put to his ear so he could "hear the ocean," Justin lifted the empty metal shell and held the hollow end to his ear. He could hear the sound of cannons, explosions, the terrified neighs of horses, the screams of wounded men. He put the shell down. Quickly.

He was about to bolt for the door when the owl he had thought was stuffed uttered a low hoot.

"Peace, Uwila," growled a voice from beyond the beaded curtain. "I'm coming!" A moment later an old man appeared. He was shorter than Justin, with long white hair and dark eyes that seemed to hold strange secrets. The old man looked at Justin for a moment, and something in his eyes grew softer. "What do you need?"

"I don't think I need anything," said Justin uncomfortably. "I just came in to look around."

"No one comes into this store just to look around, Justin. Now what do you need?"

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Justin snorted. What did he need? A real home. His mother and father back. He needed-

"Never mind," said the old man, interrupting Justin's bitter thoughts. "Let's try this. Have you ever seen a magician?" Justin nodded. "All right, then what's your favorite trick?"

Justin thought back to a time three years ago, back before his parents had had the accident. His dad had taken him to see a magician who did a trick where he locked his assistant in handcuffs, put her in a canvas bag, tied up the bag, put it in a trunk, wrapped chains around the trunk, and handed the keys to a member of the audience. Then he had climbed onto the trunk, lifted a curtain in front of himself, counted to five, and dropped the curtain. Only, when the curtain fell, the assistant was standing there, and the magician was inside the bag. "The metamorphosis!" he said suddenly, as his mind pulled the word from whatever mysterious place such things are kept.

The old man smiled and nodded. "Good choice.

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Wait there." The old man disappeared through the beaded curtain-and came back a moment later carrying a small cardboard box. "The instructions are inside. Right now, it's late, and I am tired. Take the side door. It will get you home more quickly."

Justin nodded and hurried out the side door. Je walked home slowly. The later it was when he got there, the greater the chance his uncle would be asleep. Luck was with him; Uncle Rafe lay snoring on the couch, a scattering of empty beer cans on the floor beside him.

Justin tiptoed up the stairs to his room. He set the box on his desk, then used his pocketknife to cut the tape that held it shut. The box contained two items: a small instruction book and a bag that-to Justin's astonishment-shook out to be as large as the canvas sack the magician had used. The fabric was smooth and silky, and the colors shifted and changed as he looked at it..

He opened the instruction booklet. The directions were written by hand, in a strange spidery

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script. On the first page of the booklet were the following words: WARNING: Do NOT ATTEMPT THIS TRICK UNLESS YOU REALLY MEAN IT. Do NOT EVEN TURN THE PAGE UNLESS YOU ARE SERIOUS.

Justin rolled his eyes ... and turned the page. The directions here were even weirder: *To begin the metamorphosis, open the bag and place it on your bed. Being careful not to damage the fabric, climb inside before you go to sleep. Keep your head out! After you have slept in the bag for three nights, you will receive further instructions.*

Justin stared at the bag and the booklet for a long time. He was tempted to just stuff them back in the box and take the whole crazy thing back to the old man. Only, he wasn't sure he could find the store again, even if he tried.

He rubbed the whisper-soft fabric between his fingers. It reminded him of his mother's cheek. He climbed inside the bag, feet down, head out, and slept.

Justin slept in the bag for the next two

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nights, just as the directions said. In his dreams-which grew more vivid and beautiful each night-he flew, soaring far away from his brutal uncle and the house where he had felt such pain and loss.

On the morning of the fourth day, Justin felt as if something must explode inside him, so deep was the restlessness that seized him. Eagerly, fearfully, he turned to the instruction booklet that had come with the silken sack. As he had half expected, he found new writing on the page after the last one he had read-a page that had been blank before. *Sometimes a leap of faith is all that's needed.* His shoulders itched.

The next morning they were sore and swollen. The morning after that, Justin Jones woke to find that he had wings. Justin had two reactions. Part of him wanted to shout with joy. Another part of him, calmer, more cautious, was nearly sick with fear. He knew Uncle Rafe would not approve.

To his frustration, they hung limp and useless. Late at night, when his uncle was asleep, Justin would

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flex them, in the desperate hope that they would stretch and fill, somehow find the strength to lift him, to carry him away from this place.

Exactly one week after the first night he had slept in the sack, his wings became too obvious to hide. When he sat down to breakfast that morning, his uncle snapped, "Don't slouch like that. Look how you're hunching your shoulders. Take off your shirt," said his uncle, narrowing his eyes. Slowly, nervously, Justin did as he was told. "Turn around."

Justin obeyed. He heard a sharp intake of breath, then a long silence. Finally his uncle said, "Come here, boy." Turning to face him, Justin shook his head. His uncle scowled. "I said, come here." Justin backed away instead. His uncle lurched from the table, snatching at a knife as he did. Justin turned and ran, pounding up the stairway to the attic. At the top he closed the door behind him and locked it.

A moment later he heard his uncle roaring on the other side of it. For one foolish moment Justin

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hoped he would be safe here. Then the door shuddered as his uncle threw himself against it. The door splintered into the room. Stepping through, Uncle Rafe roared, "Come here, you little heathen!"

Shaking his head, mute with fear, Justin backed away, moving step-by-step down the length of the attic, until he reached the wall and the small window at the far end. His uncle matched his pace, confident in his control.

Justin knew that once Uncle Rafe had him, the wings would be gone, ripped from his shoulders. Pressing himself against the wall, he groped behind him until he found the window latch. The wings trembled at his shoulders, and he could feel some strange power move out from them. Taking a deep breath, Justin stepped out. He fell, but only for a moment. Suddenly the wings that had hung so limp and useless snapped out from his shoulders, caught the air, slowed his fall.

They stretched to either side of him, strong and glorious. As if by instinct he knew how to move

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them. And as his uncle cried out in rage and longing behind him, Justin Jones flew, rising swiftly above the house, above the trees, his heart lifting as if it had wings of its own.

Justin flew for a long time, as far from the home of his brutal uncle as he could manage to go. After a time, he saw a cloud ahead of him. It was glowing and beautiful, and without thought, he flew into it. The air within seemed to be alive with light and electricity, and as Justin passed through the cloud he felt a tingle in his skin.

Justin's shoulders were aching. He wasn't sure how much longer he could stay aloft. And then he saw it ahead of him: a small island, maybe two or three miles across, with an inviting-looking beach.

With a sigh of relief, Justin settled to the beach. He threw himself face forward on the sand to rest. Soon he was fast asleep. When Justin opened his eyes, he saw three children squatting in front of him.

"He's awake!" said the smallest.

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"I told you he wasn't dead. They never are, no matter how bad they look."

Justin blinked, then glanced back at his shoulders. The wings were still there. Why didn't these strange children say anything about them? "Maybe I should just flyaway," he muttered.

"Oh, you can't do that," said the little girl, "Well, you could. But it wouldn't be smart. Not until you've talked to the old woman."

"So you've seen people with wings before?" asked Justin.

"Silly!" giggled the girl. "We all had wings when we came here. Were you scared when you went through the cloud? I was."

"Come on," said the biggest boy. "The old woman will tell you all. about it." Justin followed the three strange children up the beach and into the forest, a forest so perfect that it almost made him weep. It was filled with tree houses ... and the tree houses were filled with children. Happy children. Laughing children. Children who scrambled along rope

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bridges, dangled from thick branches, and swung from tree to tree on vines.

"All right. Take me to this old woman, will you please?"

"We can't take you," said the boy. "You'll have to go on your own. We can only show you the way."

Justin walked through the forest, following the path the children had shown him. The path turned a corner, and when he came out from between two trees he found himself at the edge of a large clearing, where there stood a huge, beautiful house.

The door was open. Even so, Justin knocked and called out. No one answered. Folding his wings against his back, he stepped through the door. "Old woman?" he called. "Old woman?"

"Up here!" called a voice. "I've been waiting for you." At last the stairs ended. Before him was a silver door. He put his hand against it, and it swung open.

"Come in," said the old woman. Her hair was white as cloud, her eyes blue as sky. She smiled. "I'm

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glad you're here. Do you like your wings?"

Justin reached back to touch one. "They're the most wonderful thing that ever happened to me," he said softly. "Who are you?"

She shrugged. "Just an old woman with time on her hands, trying to do a little good. Now listen carefully - The wings will only last for one more day. However, that will be long enough for you to fly home, if you should wish."

Justin snorted. "Why would I want to-"

"*Shhh!* Before you answer, you must look into my mirror. Then I will explain your choice." Standing, she took his hand and led him across the room.
On the far side was a golden door. Behind it, Justin could hear running water. When she opened the door, Justin saw not a room, but a cave. In the center of the cave was a pool.

"Kneel," said the old woman. "Look."

Justin knelt, and peered into the water. He saw his own face -- not a boy, but a man. Yet it was clearly his face. "The man you will become,"

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whispered the old woman.

Justin stared at the face. It was not handsome, as he had always hoped he would become. But it was a good face. The eyes were peaceful and calm. The beginning of a smile waited at the corners of the mouth. Laugh lines fanned out from the eyes.

"Come," she said quietly. Justin followed her back to the room. "Now you must choose," she said. "You can stay here. This place is safe and calm and no one will hurt you, ever again." Justin felt his heart lift. "But ... you will stay just as you are. Never change, never grow any older." She sighed. "That's the trade. There's always a trade."

He looked at her, startled, Justin went to the window.. He stood there a long time, looking, listening. Finally he turned to the old woman. "Can I ask a question? The man I saw in the pool. *Me.* What does he do?"

The old woman smiled. "He works with children."

Justin smiled, too. "And what about my uncle?

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Will things be better with him if I go back?" The old woman shook her head sadly.

Justin blinked. "Then how is it possible I can turn out the way you showed me? How can *that* be me?"

The old woman smiled again. "Ah, that one is easy. It is because no matter what happens, you will always remember that once upon a time ... you flew.

Justin nodded and turned back to the window. Far below he could hear the children at play. He ached to join them. But then he thought of the others he knew. The ones who never laughed. The ones who still needed wings. "How would I find the way back?"

"Take the side door," said the old woman softly. "It will get you home a little more quickly."

Tucking his wings against his back, Justin stepped through the door. He took a deep breath. Then he flew. Not toward home; Justin Jones had no real home. Flexing his wings, he pointed himself toward tomorrow and flew as hard as he could. .

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